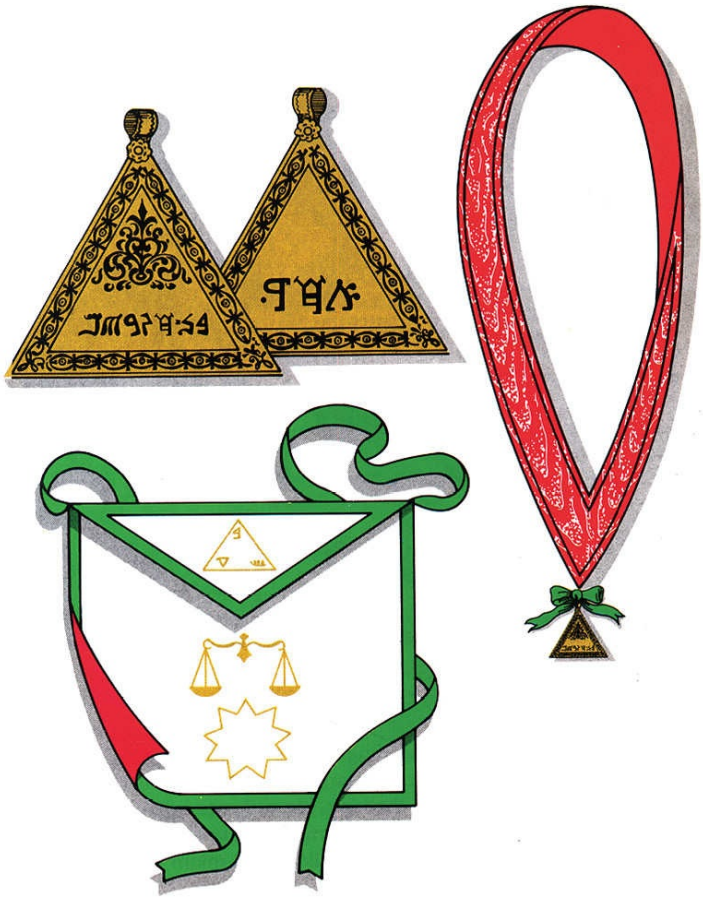
The 8th Degree – Intendant of the Building



The apron is white, lined with red and bordered with green; in the center is an embroidered nine–pointed star, and over that a balance. On the flap is a triangle, with Phoenician letters at each angle. The three colors white, red and green, the chief symbolic colors of Scottish Rite Masonry, teach us to imitate the purity of morals and zeal for the service of Masonry which have made our deceased Master immortal in the recollection of men.

The jewel is a delta of gold. On one side is engraved or enameled the words *ben–khurim* in Samaritan (𐤁𐤍𐤄𐤅𐤓𐤉𐤌), or Hebrew (בְּנֵי־חוֹרִים), both meaning "nobles" or "freeborn." On the reverse is the word achad in Samaritan (𐤀𐤇𐤃) or Hebrew (אֶחָד), signifying "our only God, chief and source of all." Pike derives this interpretation from its root which means "first." The triangular shape is the most fundamental symbol of the Deity.

The cordon is a broad watered crimson ribbon, worn from right to left; the jewel is suspended from it by a green ribbon.

DUTIES

Be benevolent and charitable.

LESSONS

Benevolence and charity demand we correct our own faults and those of others.
That which a man knows dies with him; therefore, transmit your knowledge.
Labor is honorable if done with sobriety, temperance, punctuality and industry.

FOR REFLECTION

Is this life more than a portal to another?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Triple triangle, nine pointed star, the colors crimson, green and white.

Pike reminds us in *Morals and Dogma* that these degrees are not for those who will refuse to explore the mines of wisdom in the teachings of the Scottish Rite. We may become more adept at uncovering and interpreting the meaning of the ceremonies and symbols of Masonry but this is not sufficient. Only when we have learned to practice all the virtues they inculcate are we prepared to receive its lofty philosophical instruction and to scale the heights upon whose summit Light and Truth sit enthroned.

In addition to presenting direct instruction on Masonic virtues, this degree is the first of the Ineffable Degrees to provide a summary of the important political lessons concealed within the preceding degrees.

CEREMONY

The major color of this degree is crimson, a deep red tinged with blue; it represents fervency and zeal. The second color, green, borders the apron and a separate green ribbon attaches the jewel to the cordon. Green represents renewal, such as occurs in the springtime of the year when leaves bud upon the trees—more specifically, renewal in purity of morals. As the color of the acacia, it also

reminds us of that plant which is a symbol of immortality. Suspended in the East is a nine–pointed star. Here this symbol is especially representative of divine truth. Also in the East to the right of the Master are five lights forming a square with a taller one in the center. These lights remind us of the five workmen who assumed the Master Hiram's duties, with the taller one representing Adoniram. The light in the center may also be seen as a symbol of labor; the four lights surrounding it signify sobriety, temperance, punctuality, and industry—qualities which make labor honorable.

Twenty–seven lights arranged in three groups of nine each forming a triple triangle also illuminate the lodge. The number 27 was peculiarly significant to the ancient Pythagorean numerologists, as were all multiples of nine. The multiples of nine are unique in that their products are numbers composed of individual numerals which sum to nine; for example, $9 \times 2 = 18$ and $1 + 8 = 9$; $9 \times 3 = 27$ and $2 \times 7 = 9$; this process may be continued through $9 \times 9 = 81$ and $8 + 1 = 9$. Of this series, 27 was deemed particularly significant since it was the cube of 3, the Pythagorean number of Deity. It should be noted that 27 is the number of members of a Lodge of Perfection under which these degrees are conferred. So important is this symbolic number that we shall meet with it again in subsequent degrees.

The legend of the degree portrays the events following Hiram's death. Since the period of mourning has expired, King Solomon wishes to continue work upon the Temple. The drama focuses on a solution to the problem posed by Hiram's untimely murder.

During the reception, the Master represents King Solomon. King Solomon seeks the counsel of Hiram of Tyre to solve the problem of how to complete the Temple but Ahishar offers the solution. The Master Hiram enjoyed communicating the arts and sciences he learned in Egypt and the East to a group of young men who were eager to learn. Hiram believed these young men would be able to take his place. The Master's delight in transmitting his knowledge teaches us the importance of education to maintain cultural continuity. Ahishar suggests that Hiram's favorites share the responsibility to finish the Temple. This

suggestion is accepted and the duties of the young men selected are part of the allegorical teaching presented by this story. Those selected were:

1. Gareb the Hebrew, Chief of the Workers in gold and silver, whose duty is to furnish good examples to the brethren by the practice of those virtues which adorn the character of a Mason;
2. Zelec of Gebal, Chief of the Stone Masons, whose duty is to inculcate those virtues which give strength and solidity to the character of a Mason;
3. Satolkin, Chief of the Carpenters, whose duty is to inculcate and practice the sobriety, temperance, punctuality and industry which make labor honorable. It is said Satolkin rose to the highest honors;
4. Yehu–Aber, the Phoenician, Chief of the Artificers in Bronze, whose duty is to imitate the illustrious men in their deeds of usefulness, charity and devotion to Masonry.
5. Adoniram, Superintendent of the Work, whose duty is to encourage the timid, to repress the forward and to reward the worthy.

The candidate, along with the others, is told that to become an Intendant of the Building he must not only be charitable and benevolent, he should sympathize with the working man, relieve his necessities and view himself as the almoner of God's bounty, recognizing all men as his brothers. Since we no longer work in the operative craft, the Intendant of the Building must labor in human quarries promoting works of charity and benevolence.

The province of Masonry is to teach all truth—moral, political, philosophical and religious. The political lessons of the degrees are disclosed. A system of government to which man should aspire requires:

- **4th, 5th, 6th:** *An enlightened citizenry,*
- **7th:** *An independent judiciary,*
- **8th:** *An economic order based on capital and labor.*

And finally, through a brief history of Scottish Rite Masonry, we learn that the political truths taught here have influenced history in the world and are useful to maintain the vitality of a Republic, such as that of the United States.

LECTURE

This lecture teaches many important lessons, some of which are found in the ritual of this degree and some not. Under the current of the primary duties flow lesser streams—streams of thought which also enlighten and instruct. One of the more subtle lessons taught is the importance of the transmission of knowledge. That which a man knows, dies with him. Civilization is based upon human progress, which itself depends upon knowledge acquired in one generation being transmitted to subsequent generations. How well the Master Hiram knew this, teaching his skills to those best fitted to receive them.

As he does here, Pike often uses the lectures in *Morals and Dogma* to explain Masonry—its history, doctrines and teachings—and only to hint at philosophical ideas and arguments, enticing the Mason to reflect and develop a positive approach to life. This is a process in which the Mason must participate in order to benefit. Pike explains this well:

> *We do not now enlarge upon or elaborate these ideas. We but utter them to you briefly, as hints, upon which you may at your leisure reflect. Hereafter, if you continue to advance, they will be unfolded, explained and developed* (p. 138).

In this lecture Pike expands the concepts of charity (love) and benevolence (good will) to their broadest possible interpretations. Quotations selected may not immediately bring to mind charity or benevolence; but upon reflection these import ant Masonic duties are discovered.

Benevolence and Charity:

... in the present [degree] you are taught charity and benevolence; to be to your brethren an example of virtue; to correct your own faults; and to endeavor to correct those of your brethren (pp. 136–137).

There will always be in this world wrongs to forgive, suffering to alleviate, sorrow asking for sympathy, necessities and destitution to relieve, and ample occasion for the exercise of active charity and beneficence (p. 147).

Benevolence:

The Battery of this Degree, and the five circuits which you made around the Lodge, allude to the five points of fellowship, and are intended to recall them vividly to your mind. To go upon a brother's errand or to his relief, even barefoot and upon flinty ground; to remember him in your supplications to the Deity; to clasp him to your heart, and protect him against malice and evil–speaking; to uphold him when about to stumble and fall; and to give him prudent, honest and friendly counsel, are duties plainly written upon the pages of God's great code of law, and first among the ordinances of Masonry (p. 137).

We ourselves make our fortunes good or bad; and when God lets loose a Tyrant upon us, or a sickness, or scorn, or a lessened fortune, if we fear to die, or know not how to be patient, or are proud, or covetous, then the calamity sits heavy on us. But if we know how to manage a noble principle, ... we may still bear an even mind and smile at the reverses of fortune and the ill–nature of Fate (pp. 144–145).

Compare not thy condition with the few above thee, but to secure thy content, look upon those thousands with whom thou wouldst not, for any interest, change thy fortune and condition (p. 145).

... enjoy the blessings of this day, if God sends them, and the evils of it bear patiently and calmly; for this day only is ours: we are dead to yesterday, and we are not yet born to the morrow (p. 146).

The most striking feature of the political state is not governments, nor constitutions, nor laws, nor enactments, nor the judicial power, nor the police; but the universal will of the people to be governed by the common weal. Take off that restraint, and no government on earth could stand for an hour (p. 141).

Charity:

Scarcely a Masonic discourse is pronounced, that does not demonstrate the necessity and advantages of [enlightened faith], and especially recall the two constitutive principles of religion, that make all religion,—love of God, and love of neighbor (p. 138).

The Law of our being is Love of Life, and its interests and adornments; love of the world in which our lot is cast, engrossment with the interests and affections of earth. ... Not low worldliness; but the love of Earth as the garden on which the Creator has lavished such miracles of beauty; as the habitation of humanity, the arena of its conflicts, the scene of its illimitable progress, the dwelling–place of the wise, the good, the active, the loving, and the dear; the place of opportunity for the development by means of sin and suffering and sorrow, of the noblest passions, the loftiest virtues, and the tenderest sympathies (pp. 139–140).

Of the many teachings of Masonry, one of the most valuable is, that we should not depreciate this life. It does not hold, that when we reflect on the destiny that awaits man on earth, we ought to bedew his cradle with our tears; but, like the Hebrews, it hails the birth of a child with joy, and holds that his birthday should be a festival (pp. 141–142).

On Masonry:

A Masonic Lodge should resemble a bee–hive, in which all the members work together with ardor for the common good. Masonry is not made for cold souls and narrow minds, that do not comprehend its lofty mission and sublime apostolate (p. 138).

[Masonry] *teaches that man has high duties to perform, and a high destiny to fulfill, on this earth; that this world is not merely the portal to another; and that this life, though not our only one, is an integral one, and the particular one with which we are here meant to be concerned; that the Present is our scene of action, and the Future for speculation and for trust; that man was sent upon the*

earth to live in it, to enjoy it, to study it, to love it, to embellish it, to make the most of it ... (p. 139).